

It's odd that people have strong attachments to the idea of what retirement should be. Retirement just became common in the past century, made possible by a combination of increased life expectancy and increased productivity. Before that, workers didn't retire. People worked until they died or until they were physically unable to work, at which point they were supported by their families.

When retirement was introduced, workers didn't choose to retire. Employers made the choice for them in order to make room for more productive workers. It's analogous to the way I retire a pair of old socks with a hole because they're no longer useful. Retirement was dreaded. It meant you were reaching the end of your useful life.

The finance industry seized on the opportunity to define retirement as a time of leisure. They could help you save and plan for this new phase of life. It's difficult to find a retirement planning commercial or brochure without a couple walking on a beach or a group playing golf. But is that what retirement has to be?

We need to redefine what retirement means and should be. Or maybe scrap the idea of retirement completely and focus on building lives we don't want to retire from. This is why we focus so much on the idea of FI, while not spending much time on the idea of retirement. For me, FI is all about having the freedom to spend my